
Handout: E. J. Lowe – "Necessity and Identity" (Ch. 5 of *A Survey of Metaphysics*)

The Problem: Are Identity Statements Necessarily True?

- Lowe's central question in this chapter is whether **true identity propositions** (e.g., *Hesperus is Phosphorus*) are *necessarily* true.
 - In modal terms: **If $a = b$, is it necessarily the case that $a = b$?**
 - This problem intersects with fundamental metaphysical and modal concerns:
 - The **nature of possible worlds**
 - The **distinction between necessary and contingent truths**
 - The **semantic role of names and rigid designators**
 - The **mind-body problem**, explored as a case study
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I. Two Kinds of Possibility (pp. 79–80)

Lowe distinguishes between:

- **Temporal Possibility:** What an object can *become* over time.
- **Counterfactual Possibility:** What an object *could have been* at a given time.

Example: A lump of bronze can *change shape* (temporal), but it also could *have had* a different shape now (counterfactual).

Key point: Neither form of possibility entails the other. Something could have had a different shape (counterfactual) without being able to acquire that shape in the future (temporal), and vice versa.

II. Possibility as a Dimension of Variation (pp. 80–81)

- Lowe draws a **metaphorical analogy** between possibility and spatial/temporal dimensions.
- Just as an object exists at different times, an object can be said to exist in different **possible situations** or **modal locations**.
- However, unlike times or spaces, **possible situations are not linearly ordered**.

III. Possible Worlds and Modal Semantics (pp. 81–84)

- **Possible worlds** = maximally complete and consistent sets of propositions.
 - Every proposition p is either true or not true in a given world.
 - Mutually exclusive: two different possible worlds cannot co-obtain.
- **Necessary truths** = true in *all* possible worlds (e.g., logical truths, math).
- **Contingent truths** = true in *some* but not all possible worlds.
- **Possible truths** = true in at least one world.
- Analogously:
 - **Necessary beings**: Exist in all possible worlds.
 - **Contingent beings**: Exist in some but not all.

Example: God, if He exists necessarily, exists in every possible world. Natural numbers may also be considered necessary beings.

IV. The Barcan-Kripke Argument for the Necessity of Identity (pp. 84–86)

- Goal: Prove that if $a = b$, then necessarily, $a = b$.

The Argument (Formalized):

1. Necessity of self-identity: $\Box(a = a)$
2. Leibniz's Law: If $a = b$, then whatever is true of a is true of b
3. Suppose $a = b$
4. Then a is necessarily identical with a (from 1)
5. So it's true of a that it is necessarily identical with a
6. By Leibniz's Law, it's also true of b that it is necessarily identical with a
7. Thus, $\Box(a = b)$

Conclusion: If $a = b$, then $\Box(a = b)$ — there are no contingent identity propositions.

V. Objections to the Argument (pp. 86–89)

- **Objection:** The move from line (4) to line (5) might be *question-begging*.
 - Perhaps all we can say is that a is *necessarily identical with itself*, not with a *per se*.
- This leads to a weaker version of the argument and undercuts the proof of necessity for all identity statements.

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- Lowe acknowledges the debate but thinks the proof still holds, even if not universally compelling.
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VI. The Role of Imagination and Counterexamples (pp. 87–88)

- People often imagine scenarios where identity claims turn out false (e.g., Hesperus ≠ Phosphorus).
 - Lowe argues that **imaginability ≠ genuine possibility**.
 - You might imagine twin planets that resemble Hesperus and Phosphorus, but this doesn't imply *those* are the same objects as in the actual world.
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VII. Genuine Identity Propositions vs. Definite Descriptions (pp. 88–89)

- Not all apparent identity claims are *genuine* identity propositions.
 - "The largest planet = the fifth planet from the sun" is contingent because it's built from *descriptive content*.
 - Only *purely referential expressions* (like proper names) can yield genuine identity propositions.

Key distinction: *Hesperus = Phosphorus* is a genuine identity claim. *The morning star = the evening star* is not, due to descriptive content.

VIII. Rigid Designators (pp. 89–90)

- Coined by **Kripke**: A *rigid designator* refers to the same object in all possible worlds in which it refers.
 - Lowe warns against **trivializing** the necessity of identity by building this into the definition of identity propositions.
 - The metaphysical question should not be settled by linguistic stipulation.
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IX. Transworld Identity and the Limits of Modal Language (pp. 90–92)

- Can one thing be two in another possible world? Can two things be one?
 - These questions test the **transitivity of identity** across worlds.
- Example: If Tom and Jack are identical twins, could they have been *one* person if their zygote hadn't split?

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- Lowe thinks it's not obvious how to answer this, revealing **the complexities of modal identity**.
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X. Application: Identity and the Mind-Body Problem (pp. 93–95)

- Suppose someone claims: *I am identical with my body (B)*.
- But it seems *possible* that I exist without B (e.g., disembodied).
- By the necessity of identity:
 - If $I \neq B$ in any possible world, then $I \neq B$ in *all* worlds.
- Therefore, if disembodied existence is possible, $I \neq$ my body.

Implication: If the necessity of identity holds, then identity claims—such as materialist claims in the philosophy of mind—are far stronger than they may appear.

Conclusion: Lowe's Metaphysical Commitments

- Lowe ultimately *accepts* the necessity of identity, though he grants that some routes to that conclusion are questionable.
 - He believes metaphysical necessity is grounded in the nature of things—not just our language or concepts.
 - Identity statements, if true, must be necessarily true—but proving this requires careful attention to how names refer, what propositions are, and how we interpret possibility.
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